

THE WESTMINSTER CONFESSION OF FAITH

In Plain English — with Summaries

A point-by-point simplification for everyday readers,
with a one-line summary beside every section

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Chapter 1 — The Bible

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. Nature itself — creation, and the way God cares for the world — shows that God is good, wise, and powerful. That's enough to leave people without excuse, but not enough to tell us how to be saved. So God revealed himself directly to his people over time, and eventually had that revelation written down. Now that God no longer reveals himself in those older ways, the written Bible is absolutely essential.	<i>Nature reveals God but can't save; so God gave us the written Bible.</i>
2. The Bible consists of the 66 books of the Old and New Testaments (the familiar list, Genesis through Revelation). All of them are inspired by God and are the rule for what we believe and how we live.	<i>The Bible is the 66 books — our rule for faith and life.</i>
3. <i>(The books called the Apocrypha are not inspired; they are merely human writings.)</i>	<i>The Apocrypha is not Scripture.</i>
4. The Bible's authority doesn't come from any person or church saying so. It comes from God, its author. We accept it because it is God's Word.	<i>The Bible's authority comes from God, not from the church.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
5. The church's testimony can move us to respect the Bible, and the Bible itself carries plenty of evidence that it's God's Word — its content, power, style, consistency, and purpose. But full, settled conviction that it's true comes only from the Holy Spirit working in our hearts.	<i>Full conviction that it's God's Word comes from the Holy Spirit.</i>
6. Everything we need to know for God's glory and our salvation and life is either stated in the Bible or can be soundly reasoned from it. Nothing is ever to be added — not new "revelations," not human traditions. Still, we need the Spirit's help to truly understand it, and some practical details of worship and church life (things common to all human gatherings) are left to common sense guided by the Bible's general rules.	<i>Scripture contains everything we need; nothing may be added.</i>
7. Not everything in the Bible is equally easy to understand. But everything necessary for salvation is stated so clearly somewhere in it that anyone — educated or not — can understand it by ordinary means (reading, listening, studying).	<i>Everything needed for salvation is clear enough for anyone.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
8. God inspired the Old Testament in Hebrew and the New Testament in Greek, and has kept them pure through the ages; they are the final court of appeal in every religious dispute. But since most people don't read Hebrew and Greek, and everyone has a right to the Scriptures, the Bible should be translated into the everyday language of every nation.	<i>God preserved the originals; the Bible should be translated for everyone.</i>
9. The Bible interprets itself. When a passage is hard to understand, look for other passages that speak more clearly on the same subject — each passage has one true meaning, not many.	<i>Scripture interprets Scripture.</i>
10. The final judge in all religious controversies — above councils, ancient writers, human teachings, and claimed private revelations — is the Holy Spirit speaking in the Bible. His verdict settles the matter.	<i>The final judge in every controversy is the Spirit speaking in Scripture.</i>

Chapter 2 — God and the Trinity

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. There is only one living and true God. He is infinite, perfect, pure spirit — invisible, without a body, unchangeable, eternal, beyond our full comprehension, all-powerful, completely wise, completely holy, and completely free. He does everything according to his own righteous will and for his own glory. He is deeply loving, gracious, merciful, patient, and forgiving — and at the same time perfectly just, hating all sin and never clearing the guilty.	<i>There is one true God, perfect in every way — both loving and just.</i>
2. God has all life, glory, goodness, and happiness in himself. He doesn't need anything he has made; instead, he displays his glory in and through his creation. He is the source of everything, rules over everything, sees everything, and knows everything — nothing is uncertain to him. Every creature owes him whatever worship, service, and obedience he requires.	<i>God is self-sufficient, sovereign, and all-knowing; every creature owes him worship.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH**IN BRIEF**

3. Within the one God there are three persons — the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit — equal in substance, power, and eternity. The Father is of no one; the Son is eternally begotten of the Father; the Spirit eternally proceeds from the Father and the Son.

One God in three persons: Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Chapter 3 — God's Eternal Plan

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. From all eternity, God freely and unchangeably planned everything that happens. Yet he did it in such a way that he is not the author of sin, no one's will is forced, and real causes and real choices still operate — his plan actually establishes them rather than erasing them.	<i>God planned everything that happens — yet is never the author of sin.</i>
2. God knows everything that could happen under any circumstances, but his plan isn't based on foreseeing what people would do. He didn't decree things because he saw them coming.	<i>God's plan isn't based on foreseeing what we would do.</i>
3. By God's decree, some people and angels are predestined to everlasting life, and others are left to everlasting death.	<i>Some are predestined to life; others are left to death.</i>
4. These individuals are specifically and unchangeably chosen; their number is fixed and can't be increased or decreased.	<i>The number of the elect is fixed and unchangeable.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
5. Before the world was made, God chose those predestined to life — in Christ, for everlasting glory. He chose them purely out of his free grace and love, not because he foresaw their faith, good works, or anything else in them. It is all to the praise of his glorious grace.	<i>God chose his people by grace alone, not foreseen faith or works.</i>
6. God planned not only the destination but the means of getting there. So the elect — all fallen in Adam — are redeemed by Christ, called to faith by the Spirit, justified, adopted, sanctified, and kept by God's power to final salvation. Only the elect receive these things.	<i>God planned the means of salvation as well as the destination.</i>
7. The rest of mankind God chose to pass by, according to his own unsearchable will, by which he shows or withholds mercy as he pleases — leaving them to dishonor and wrath for their sin, to the praise of his justice.	<i>The rest God passes by, to the praise of his justice.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH**IN BRIEF**

8. This deep and mysterious doctrine should be handled with special care and wisdom. Its purpose is that people, paying attention to God's revealed will and obeying it, may become assured of their own election from the evidence of their calling. Handled rightly, it leads to praise and reverence toward God, and to humility, diligence, and rich comfort for all who sincerely follow the gospel.

Handle this doctrine with care; rightly used, it brings humility and comfort.

Chapter 4 — Creation

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. In the beginning, God — Father, Son, and Holy Spirit — created the world and everything in it, visible and invisible, out of nothing, in the space of six days, and all of it very good. He did this to display his eternal power, wisdom, and goodness.	<i>God made everything from nothing, in six days, and all very good.</i>
2. Last of all, God created human beings, male and female, with rational, immortal souls. He made them in his own image — with knowledge, righteousness, and true holiness — with God's law written on their hearts and the power to keep it. Yet they were able to fall, being left to the freedom of their own changeable will. Besides the law in their hearts, they were given one command: not to eat from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. As long as they obeyed, they were happy in fellowship with God and ruled over the creatures.	<i>Humans were made in God's image — able to obey, but also able to fall.</i>

Chapter 5 — Providence (How God Runs the World)

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. God, the great Creator, upholds, directs, arranges, and governs all creatures, all actions, all things — from the greatest to the smallest — with perfect wisdom and holiness, according to his unfailing knowledge and his free, unchangeable will, to the praise of his wisdom, power, justice, goodness, and mercy.	<i>God governs all things, from the greatest to the smallest.</i>
2. From God's point of view, everything happens unchangeably and infallibly, exactly as he decreed. Yet by that same providence, he arranges events to unfold through ordinary causes — some things happening necessarily, some freely, some by chance (from our perspective).	<i>God's unchangeable plan works through ordinary causes and real choices.</i>
3. God ordinarily works through means — normal processes and instruments — but he is free to work without them, above them, or against them whenever he pleases.	<i>God normally works through means, but is free to work without them.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
4. God's providence extends even to the first fall and to every sin of angels and men — not by merely allowing them, but by an allowance joined with wise and powerful limiting, ordering, and governing of them for his own holy purposes. Yet the sinfulness comes entirely from the creatures, never from God, who neither is nor can be the author or approver of sin.	<i>Even sin is under God's governing control — but never his fault.</i>
5. God, in his wisdom, often leaves even his own children to face temptations and the corruption of their own hearts for a time — to discipline them for past sins, to humble them by showing them what's really hidden in their hearts, to drive them to depend on him more closely and constantly, to make them more watchful against sin in the future, and for other just and holy purposes.	<i>God lets his children face trials for their own good.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
6. As for wicked and ungodly people whom God, as a righteous judge, blinds and hardens because of their previous sins: he withholds the grace that could have enlightened them, sometimes takes away gifts they had, exposes them to situations their corruption turns into occasions for sin, and gives them over to their own desires, the world's temptations, and Satan's power. The result is that they harden themselves even under the very influences God uses to soften others.	<i>God justly blinds and hardens the wicked.</i>
7. God's providence covers all creatures in general, but in a very special way it cares for his church and arranges everything for its good.	<i>Providence takes special care of the church.</i>

Chapter 6 — The Fall, Sin, and Its Punishment

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. Our first parents were tempted by the cunning of Satan and sinned by eating the forbidden fruit. God permitted this sin according to his wise and holy plan, having purposed to bring glory to himself through it.	<i>Adam and Eve sinned; God permitted it for his own glory.</i>
2. By this sin they lost their original righteousness and their fellowship with God. They became dead in sin and completely corrupted in every part of soul and body.	<i>The fall brought spiritual death and total corruption.</i>
3. Because Adam and Eve were the root of the whole human race, the guilt of their sin was credited to all their natural descendants — and the same spiritual death and corrupted nature was passed down to them.	<i>Adam's guilt and corrupted nature passed to all his descendants.</i>
4. From this original corruption — which leaves us thoroughly unwilling, unable, and opposed to everything good, and inclined toward everything evil — all our actual sins flow.	<i>All our actual sins flow from this corrupt nature.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
5. This corrupt nature remains in believers during this life. Even though it is pardoned and being put to death through Christ, both the corruption itself and everything that comes from it are truly and properly sin.	<i>Corruption remains even in believers — and it is still sin.</i>
6. Every sin — both our inherited corruption and our actual sins — breaks God's righteous law. So every sin brings guilt on the sinner, placing him under God's wrath and the law's curse, and making him subject to death and to every kind of misery — spiritual, physical, and eternal.	<i>Every sin deserves God's wrath, the law's curse, and death.</i>

Chapter 7 — God's Covenant with Humanity

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. The gap between God and his creatures is so great that even though rational beings owe him obedience as their Creator, they could never enjoy him as their reward unless God voluntarily stooped down to their level. He has been pleased to do this by way of covenant — a binding agreement.	<i>God graciously stooped down to relate to us by covenant.</i>
2. The first covenant was a covenant of works: life was promised to Adam, and in him to his descendants, on the condition of perfect, personal obedience.	<i>The first covenant: works — life promised for perfect obedience.</i>
3. When man's fall made that covenant impossible to keep, the Lord made a second covenant, commonly called the covenant of grace. In it, God freely offers sinners life and salvation through Jesus Christ, requiring faith in him — and promising to give his Holy Spirit to all who are appointed to eternal life, making them willing and able to believe.	<i>The second covenant: grace — salvation freely offered through faith in Christ.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
4. This covenant of grace is sometimes called a "testament" (a will) in Scripture — pointing to the death of Jesus Christ, the one who made the will, and the everlasting inheritance he left to his people in it.	<i>This covenant is like a will, sealed by Christ's death.</i>
5. This covenant was administered differently in Old Testament times than it is now. Back then it came through promises, prophecies, sacrifices, circumcision, the Passover lamb, and other symbols pointing ahead to Christ. For that era these were sufficient and effective, through the Spirit's work, to build up God's chosen people in faith in the coming Messiah — through whom they received full forgiveness and eternal salvation.	<i>Under the law it came through symbols pointing forward to Christ.</i>

6. Now that Christ, the reality behind the symbols, has come, the covenant is administered through the preaching of the Word and the two sacraments: baptism and the Lord's Supper. These are fewer and simpler than the old ceremonies, yet in them the covenant is presented with greater fullness, clarity, and spiritual power — to all nations. So there are not two covenants of grace, but one and the same covenant administered in different ways.

*Under the gospel:
Word and sacraments.
One covenant, two
administrations.*

Chapter 8 — Christ the Mediator

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. In his eternal plan, God chose and appointed the Lord Jesus, his only begotten Son, to be the go-between — the mediator — between God and man: prophet, priest, and king; the Head and Savior of the church; the heir of all things; and the judge of the world. From all eternity, God gave him a people to be redeemed, called, justified, sanctified, and glorified by him.	<i>God appointed Jesus as mediator: prophet, priest, and king.</i>
2. The Son of God — the second person of the Trinity, truly and eternally God, equal with the Father — took human nature to himself when the right time came, with all its essential properties and ordinary weaknesses, yet without sin. He was conceived by the power of the Holy Spirit in the womb of the virgin Mary, of her flesh. So two whole natures — divine and human — were joined inseparably in one person, without being changed, blended, or confused. This person is truly God and truly man, yet one Christ, the only mediator between God and man.	<i>The eternal Son became truly human — one person, two natures.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
3. In his human nature, Jesus was anointed with the Holy Spirit beyond measure, having in himself all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge. The Father was pleased to have all fullness dwell in him, so that — holy, blameless, full of grace and truth — he would be fully equipped for the work of mediator and guarantor. He didn't seize this role; his Father called him to it and gave all power and judgment into his hands.	<i>Jesus was perfectly equipped for the work, and called to it by the Father.</i>
4. Jesus took on this work completely willingly. To carry it out, he was born under the law and kept it perfectly. He endured terrible agony in his soul and painful suffering in his body; he was crucified, died, and was buried; he remained under death's power for a time, yet his body never decayed. On the third day he rose from the dead with the same body in which he had suffered, ascended into heaven in that body, and now sits at his Father's right hand praying for his people. He will return to judge men and angels at the end of the age.	<i>He obeyed, suffered, died, rose, ascended — and will return to judge.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
5. By his perfect obedience and by offering himself up as a sacrifice once for all, Jesus fully satisfied his Father's justice. He purchased not only reconciliation with God but an everlasting inheritance in the kingdom of heaven — for everyone the Father has given him.	<i>His sacrifice fully satisfied God's justice for all his people.</i>
6. Although Christ's redeeming work wasn't actually accomplished until after his incarnation, its power and benefits were applied to God's chosen people in every previous age — through the promises, symbols, and sacrifices that revealed him as the offspring of the woman who would crush the serpent's head, the Lamb slain from the world's beginning. He is the same yesterday, today, and forever.	<i>Its benefits reached believers even before he came.</i>
7. In his work as mediator, Christ acts according to both natures, each nature doing what belongs to it. Yet because he is one person, Scripture sometimes attributes what belongs to one nature to the person named by the other nature.	<i>Christ acts in both natures, yet as one person.</i>

8. Christ certainly and effectively applies redemption to everyone for whom he purchased it. He intercedes for them, reveals the mysteries of salvation to them in and through the Word, persuades them by his Spirit to believe and obey, governs their hearts by his Word and Spirit, and overcomes all their enemies by his almighty power and wisdom — in the ways that best fit his wonderful and unsearchable governing of all things.

Christ certainly and effectively saves everyone he redeemed.

Chapter 9 — Free Will

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. God gave the human will a natural freedom: it is neither forced nor locked by nature into doing good or evil.	<i>The human will is naturally free — never forced.</i>
2. In his innocence, before the fall, man had the freedom and the ability to will and do what was good and pleasing to God — but not unchangeably. He could still fall from it, and he did.	<i>Before the fall: free and able to do good, but able to fall.</i>
3. By falling into sin, man completely lost the ability to choose any spiritual good connected with salvation. An unconverted person — opposed to that good and dead in sin — cannot convert himself or even prepare himself for conversion by his own strength.	<i>After the fall: unable to choose saving good.</i>
4. When God converts a sinner and brings him into a state of grace, he frees him from his natural slavery to sin and, by grace alone, enables him to freely will and do what is spiritually good. Yet because corruption still remains in him, he doesn't will only good, and doesn't will it perfectly — he still wills evil too.	<i>In grace: freed to will what is good, though still imperfectly.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH**IN BRIEF**

5. The human will becomes perfectly and unchangeably free to do good alone only in heaven — the state of glory.

In glory: perfectly and permanently free to do good alone.

Chapter 10 — Effectual Calling (How God Draws People to Himself)

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. All those God has predestined to life — and only those — he effectively calls at his appointed time, by his Word and Spirit, out of their natural state of sin and death into grace and salvation through Jesus Christ. In this calling, God enlightens their minds so they can truly understand the things of God, replaces their hearts of stone with hearts of flesh, renews their wills, and by his almighty power turns them toward what is good and draws them to Jesus Christ. Yet they come completely freely — because his grace has made them willing.	<i>God effectively calls all his elect — and makes them willing.</i>
2. This effective call comes from God's free and special grace alone, not from anything God foresees in the person. The person is entirely passive in it until, made alive and renewed by the Holy Spirit, he is enabled to answer the call and embrace the grace offered in it.	<i>The call is by grace alone; we are passive until the Spirit renews us.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
3. Elect infants who die in infancy are regenerated and saved by Christ through the Spirit, who works when, where, and how he pleases. The same is true of all other elect persons who are incapable of being outwardly called through the preaching of the Word.	<i>Elect infants, and others unable to hear the Word, are saved by the Spirit.</i>
4. Others, who are not elect, may hear the Word preached and even experience some ordinary workings of the Spirit — but they never truly come to Christ, and so cannot be saved. Still less can people who don't profess Christianity be saved by any other means, no matter how carefully they live by the light of nature or the rules of their own religion. To claim they can is very harmful and to be rejected.	<i>Apart from Christ and this calling, no one is saved.</i>

Chapter 11 — Justification (How God Declares Sinners Righteous)

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. Those God effectively calls, he also freely justifies — not by pouring righteousness into them, but by pardoning their sins and counting and accepting them as righteous. This isn't because of anything worked in them or done by them, but for Christ's sake alone. God doesn't count their faith itself, or their believing, or any other act of obedience as their righteousness. Instead, he credits Christ's obedience and payment for sin to those who receive and rest on Christ and his righteousness by faith — a faith they don't produce themselves; it is the gift of God.	<i>God justifies by crediting Christ's righteousness, received by faith alone.</i>
2. Faith — receiving and resting on Christ and his righteousness — is the only instrument of justification. But it never comes alone in the justified person; it is always accompanied by every other saving grace. Justifying faith isn't dead faith; it works through love.	<i>Faith is the only instrument — but it never comes alone.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
3. By his obedience and death, Christ fully paid the debt of all who are justified — a proper, real, and full satisfaction of his Father's justice on their behalf. Yet because the Father freely gave Christ for them and freely accepted his work in their place — not because of anything in them — their justification is entirely a matter of free grace. In justifying sinners, God's purpose was to glorify both his strict justice and his rich grace.	<i>Christ fully paid the debt; justification is entirely free grace.</i>
4. From all eternity God decreed to justify the elect, and in due time Christ died for their sins and rose again for their justification. Nevertheless, no one is actually justified until the Holy Spirit, at the right time, actually applies Christ to them.	<i>Decreed in eternity, accomplished at the cross, applied in time by the Spirit.</i>
5. God continues to forgive the sins of those who are justified. They can never fall out of the state of justification, but they can, by their sins, fall under God's fatherly displeasure — and not have the light of his face restored until they humble themselves, confess their sin, ask for pardon, and renew their faith and repentance.	<i>The justified stay justified — but sin brings God's fatherly displeasure.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH**IN BRIEF**

6. Believers in Old Testament times were justified in exactly the same way as believers in New Testament times.

Old Testament believers were justified in exactly the same way.

Chapter 12 — Adoption

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. All who are justified, God graciously guarantees to make his adopted children — in and through his only Son, Jesus Christ. They are numbered among God's children and enjoy the freedoms and privileges of that relationship: they bear his name, receive the Spirit of adoption, come boldly to the throne of grace, and are enabled to cry "Abba, Father." Like a father, God has compassion on them, protects them, provides for them, and disciplines them — yet he will never cast them off. They are sealed for the day of redemption and will inherit the promises as heirs of everlasting salvation.	<i>The justified are adopted as God's own children — forever.</i>

Chapter 13 — Sanctification (Growing in Holiness)

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. Those who are effectively called and regenerated — given a new heart and a new spirit — are then further sanctified, truly and personally, through the power of Christ's death and resurrection and by his Word and Spirit living in them. Sin's overall rule in them is broken; its various desires are more and more weakened and put to death; and they are more and more brought to life and strengthened in every saving grace, leading to the practice of true holiness, without which no one will see the Lord.	<i>Believers are progressively made holy by Christ's Word and Spirit.</i>
2. This sanctification affects the whole person but remains imperfect in this life. Traces of corruption persist in every part of us, which produces a continual, irreconcilable war: the flesh fighting against the Spirit, and the Spirit against the flesh.	<i>Sanctification is real but imperfect — a lifelong inner war.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH**IN BRIEF**

3. In that war, the remaining corruption may get the upper hand for a time. Yet through the continual supply of strength from the sanctifying Spirit of Christ, the regenerated part wins out — and so believers grow in grace, maturing in holiness in the fear of God.

By the Spirit's strength, the believer grows and finally wins.

Chapter 14 — Saving Faith

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. The grace of faith, by which the elect are enabled to believe and be saved, is the work of Christ's Spirit in their hearts. It is normally produced through the preaching of the Word, and strengthened by the Word, the sacraments, and prayer.	<i>Faith is the Spirit's work, usually born through preaching.</i>
2. By this faith, a Christian believes everything revealed in the Bible is true, because God himself speaks in it. And he responds to each passage according to what it contains — obeying its commands, trembling at its warnings, embracing its promises for this life and the life to come. But the principal acts of saving faith are accepting, receiving, and resting on Christ alone for justification, sanctification, and eternal life, by virtue of the covenant of grace.	<i>Faith believes all of Scripture and rests on Christ alone.</i>
3. This faith comes in different strengths — weak or strong. It may be attacked and weakened often and in many ways, but it wins in the end. In many believers it grows into full assurance through Christ, who is both the author and the perfecter of our faith.	<i>Faith may be weak or strong — but it gains the victory.</i>

Chapter 15 — Repentance unto Life

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. Repentance unto life is a gospel grace, and its doctrine should be preached by every minister of the gospel, just as the doctrine of faith in Christ is.	<i>Repentance must be preached, right alongside faith.</i>
2. In repentance, a sinner sees and feels not just the danger of his sins but their filthiness and hatefulness — as things contrary to God's holy nature and righteous law. Grasping that God promises mercy in Christ to those who repent, he turns from all his sins to God, grieving over them and hating them, and resolves to walk with God in all his ways.	<i>Repentance means hating sin and turning to God.</i>
3. Repentance isn't a payment for sin or a cause of pardon — pardon is God's act of free grace in Christ. Yet repentance is so necessary that no sinner may expect pardon without it.	<i>Repentance doesn't earn pardon — but there's no pardon without it.</i>
4. No sin is so small that it doesn't deserve damnation. And no sin is so great that it can damn those who truly repent.	<i>No sin is too small to condemn; none too great to be forgiven.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
5. No one should settle for a vague, general repentance. It's everyone's duty to try to repent of each particular sin, particularly.	<i>Repent of specific sins, specifically.</i>
6. Everyone should privately confess his sins to God and pray for pardon — and whoever confesses, prays for forgiveness, and forsakes his sins will find mercy. Likewise, anyone who has wronged a brother or scandalized the church ought to be willing, by private or public confession and sorrow, to declare his repentance to those he offended — and they in turn should be reconciled to him and receive him in love.	<i>Confess to God — and to the people you have wronged.</i>

Chapter 16 — Good Works

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. Good works are only those God has commanded in his Word — not things people invent out of blind zeal or good intentions without any warrant from Scripture.	<i>Good works are what God commands — not human inventions.</i>
2. Good works, done in obedience to God's commands, are the fruit and evidence of a true, living faith. Through them believers show their thankfulness, strengthen their assurance, build up fellow believers, adorn their profession of the gospel, silence the critics, and glorify God — for they are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, so that bearing fruit toward holiness, they may reach the goal: eternal life.	<i>Good works are the fruit and evidence of real faith.</i>
3. The ability to do good works doesn't come from believers themselves at all, but entirely from the Spirit of Christ. Beyond the graces they've already received, they need the actual influence of the Spirit working in them "to will and to do" God's good pleasure. But that's no excuse for laziness, as if they had no duties until they felt a special prompting of the Spirit — rather, they ought to be diligent in stirring up the grace of God that is in them.	<i>The ability comes entirely from the Spirit — yet stay diligent.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
4. Even those who reach the greatest heights of obedience possible in this life can't do more than God requires — in fact, they fall far short of what duty demands.	<i>Even the best believers fall short of their full duty.</i>
5. Even our best works can't earn forgiveness or eternal life from God. There's too great a gap between our works and the glory to come, and an infinite distance between us and God. Our best deeds can't profit God or pay for our past sins; when we've done all we can, we've only done our duty, and are unprofitable servants. Whatever is good in our works comes from the Spirit; and whatever comes from us is so weak and imperfect that it could never survive the strictness of God's judgment.	<i>Our best works can never earn anything from God.</i>
6. Even so, because believers themselves are accepted through Christ, their good works are also accepted in him — not because they're flawless in God's sight, but because God, looking on them in his Son, is pleased to accept and reward what is sincere, even though it comes with many weaknesses and imperfections.	<i>Yet God graciously accepts believers' sincere works in Christ.</i>

7. Works done by unregenerate people may be, in themselves, things God commands, and useful to themselves and others. But because they don't flow from a heart purified by faith, aren't done in the right manner according to the Word, and aren't done for the right end — the glory of God — they are sinful, cannot please God, and don't make anyone fit to receive grace. Yet neglecting them is even more sinful and displeasing to God.

believers' 'good' works aren't truly good — but neglecting them is worse.

Chapter 17 — The Perseverance of the Saints (Once Saved, Kept Saved)

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. Those whom God has accepted in Christ, effectively called, and sanctified by his Spirit can never totally or finally fall away from the state of grace. They will certainly persevere in it to the end and be eternally saved.	<i>True believers can never totally or finally fall away.</i>
2. This perseverance doesn't depend on their own free will. It rests on the unchangeable decree of election flowing from God the Father's free and unchangeable love; on the effectiveness of Christ's merit and intercession; on the abiding presence of the Spirit and the seed of God within them; and on the nature of the covenant of grace. These make their perseverance certain and infallible.	<i>Their security rests on God — not on themselves.</i>
3. Even so, believers may — through Satan's temptations, the world, the strength of the corruption remaining in them, and neglect of the means meant to preserve them — fall into serious sins and continue in them for a time. When they do, they displease God and grieve his Holy Spirit; they lose some measure of his graces and comforts; their hearts harden and their consciences are wounded; they hurt others and give them occasion to sin; and they bring temporal judgments on themselves.	<i>They can still fall into serious sin, with real consequences.</i>

Chapter 18 — Assurance of Salvation

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. Hypocrites and other unconverted people may fool themselves with false hopes that they're in God's favor — but that hope will perish. Those who truly believe in the Lord Jesus, love him sincerely, and strive to live with a good conscience before him, however, may in this life be certainly assured that they are in a state of grace, and may rejoice in the hope of the glory of God — a hope that will never put them to shame.	<i>False hope perishes; true believers can have genuine assurance.</i>
2. This certainty isn't a hopeful guess based on probabilities. It's an infallible assurance of faith, founded on the divine truth of God's promises of salvation, on the inward evidence of those graces the promises speak of, and on the testimony of the Spirit of adoption witnessing with our spirits that we are God's children. That Spirit is the down payment of our inheritance, by whom we are sealed for the day of redemption.	<i>Assurance rests on God's promises, inward evidence, and the Spirit's witness.</i>

3. This infallible assurance isn't automatic to faith — a true believer may wait a long time and struggle through many difficulties before receiving it. Yet since the Spirit enables him to know what God has freely given him, he can attain it by the ordinary means, without any special revelation. So it's everyone's duty to be diligent to make his calling and election sure. Doing so enlarges the heart with peace and joy in the Holy Spirit, with love and thankfulness to God, and with strength and cheerfulness in obedience — the natural fruits of assurance. Far from making people careless, assurance does the opposite.

Assurance may take time — pursue it diligently; it fuels obedience.

4. True believers may have their assurance shaken, weakened, or interrupted in various ways: by neglecting to preserve it, by falling into some particular sin that wounds the conscience and grieves the Spirit, by a sudden or violent temptation, or by God withdrawing the light of his face and letting even those who fear him walk in darkness for a time. Yet they are never left utterly without the seed of God, the life of faith, the love of Christ and fellow believers, and the sincerity of heart from which — by the Spirit's work — assurance can in due time be revived; and which, in the meantime, keeps them from utter despair.

Assurance can be shaken, but never finally destroyed.

Chapter 19 — The Law of God

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. God gave Adam a law, as a covenant of works, binding him and all his descendants to personal, entire, exact, and perpetual obedience. He promised life for keeping it and threatened death for breaking it — and gave Adam the power and ability to keep it.	<i>God gave Adam the law as a covenant of works.</i>
2. After the fall, this law continued to be a perfect standard of righteousness. God delivered it at Mount Sinai in the Ten Commandments, written on two stone tablets — the first four commandments covering our duty to God, the other six our duty to our fellow man.	<i>That same law continues in the Ten Commandments.</i>
3. Besides this moral law, God gave Israel — the church in its childhood — ceremonial laws, containing symbolic ordinances: partly worship rituals that prefigured Christ, his graces, actions, sufferings, and benefits; and partly instructions about moral duties. All these ceremonial laws are now abolished under the New Testament.	<i>The ceremonial laws pointed to Christ and are now abolished.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
4. To Israel as a nation, God also gave various civil laws, which expired when that state expired. They obligate no one today, except insofar as they embody general principles of justice.	<i>Israel's civil laws expired; only their principles of justice remain.</i>
5. The moral law, however, binds everyone, forever — justified and unjustified alike — not only because of what it contains, but because of the authority of God the Creator, who gave it. Christ, in the gospel, in no way dissolves this obligation; he greatly strengthens it.	<i>The moral law binds everyone, always.</i>
6. True believers are not under the law as a covenant of works — it can neither justify nor condemn them. But it remains extremely useful to them (and to everyone). As a rule of life, it informs them of God's will and their duty and directs them to walk accordingly. It exposes the sinful pollution of their nature, hearts, and lives, so that examining themselves by it, they come to deeper conviction of, humility for, and hatred of their sin — along with a clearer view of their need of Christ and the perfection of his obedience. It restrains their corruptions by forbidding sin; its warnings show what	<i>Believers aren't under the law for salvation — but it still guides, convicts, and restrains.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH**IN BRIEF**

their sins deserve and what afflictions they may expect in this life, even though they're freed from its curse; and its promises show God's approval of obedience and the blessings that obedience may bring — though not as something owed under a covenant of works. Doing good and avoiding evil because the law encourages one and discourages the other is no evidence that a person is under law rather than grace.

7. These uses of the law don't conflict with the grace of the gospel; they fit together perfectly. For it is the Spirit of Christ who subdues and enables our wills to do freely and cheerfully what the will of God, revealed in the law, requires.

Law and gospel are not enemies; they work in harmony.

Chapter 20 — Christian Liberty and Freedom of Conscience

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. The liberty Christ purchased for believers under the gospel includes: freedom from the guilt of sin, from God's condemning wrath, and from the curse of the moral law; deliverance from this present evil age, from bondage to Satan, from the dominion of sin, from the evil of afflictions, from the sting of death, from the victory of the grave, and from everlasting damnation. It also includes free access to God and the ability to obey him not out of slavish fear, but out of childlike love and a willing mind. All this was true of believers under the law as well. But under the New Testament, Christian liberty is enlarged further: freedom from the yoke of the ceremonial law, greater boldness of access to the throne of grace, and a fuller measure of God's free Spirit than believers under the law ordinarily experienced.	<i>Christ freed believers from guilt, wrath, bondage, and fear.</i>
2. God alone is Lord of the conscience. He has left it free from any human doctrines and commandments that are contrary to his Word, or that add to it in matters of faith or worship. So to believe such doctrines, or to obey such commands, out of conscience, is to betray true liberty of conscience — and requiring implicit faith or absolute, blind obedience destroys both liberty of conscience and reason itself.	<i>God alone is Lord of the conscience.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
3. Those who use "Christian liberty" as an excuse to practice any sin or nurse any evil desire destroy the whole point of Christian liberty — which is that, having been rescued from the hands of our enemies, we might serve the Lord without fear, in holiness and righteousness before him, all our days.	<i>Liberty is never an excuse for sin.</i>
4. The authorities God has ordained and the liberty Christ has purchased are not meant to destroy each other, but to uphold and preserve each other. So those who, in the name of Christian liberty, oppose any lawful authority — civil or church — or its lawful exercise, are resisting God's ordinance. And those who spread opinions or practices contrary to the light of nature, to known Christian principles (of faith, worship, or conduct), or to the power of godliness — or whose errors, by their nature or the way they're promoted, destroy the external peace and order Christ has established in the church — may lawfully be called to account and disciplined by the church.	<i>Liberty doesn't overthrow lawful authority in state or church.</i>

Chapter 21 — Worship and the Sabbath

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. Nature itself teaches that there is a God who is Lord over all, good and doing good to all, and therefore to be feared, loved, praised, called upon, trusted, and served with all the heart, soul, and might. But the acceptable way of worshiping the true God is instituted by God himself, and limited by his own revealed will. He may not be worshiped according to human imagination or invention, or Satan's suggestions, or under any visible image, or in any way not commanded in Scripture.	<i>Worship God only in the ways he has commanded.</i>
2. Worship is to be given to God alone — Father, Son, and Holy Spirit — not to angels, saints, or any other creature. And since the fall, worship is only acceptable through a mediator — and through no mediator but Christ.	<i>Worship God alone — and only through Christ.</i>
3. Prayer with thanksgiving is a special part of worship, required by God of everyone. To be accepted, it must be made in the name of the Son, with the Spirit's help, according to God's will — with understanding, reverence, humility, fervency, faith, love, and perseverance; and if spoken aloud, in a language people understand.	<i>Prayer is required: reverent, believing, and understandable.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
4. We are to pray for lawful things, and for all kinds of people alive now or yet to be born. But we are not to pray for the dead, or for those known to have committed the "sin unto death."	<i>Pray for the living — not for the dead.</i>
5. The elements of ordinary worship are: reading the Scriptures with reverence; sound preaching and conscientious hearing of the Word in obedience to God, with understanding, faith, and reverence; singing psalms with grace in the heart; and the proper administration and worthy receiving of the sacraments Christ instituted. On special occasions, worship also includes religious oaths, vows, solemn fasts, and thanksgivings, used in a holy and devout manner.	<i>Worship consists of Scripture, preaching, singing, and the sacraments.</i>
6. Under the gospel, no prayer or worship is tied to — or made better by — any particular place or direction. God is to be worshiped everywhere, in spirit and truth: daily in families, privately by individuals, and with greater solemnity in public services, which are not to be carelessly or willfully neglected or abandoned when God, by his Word or providence, calls us to them.	<i>Worship isn't tied to sacred places — worship everywhere, and gather publicly.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
7. It's a law of nature that some proportion of time should be set apart for worshipping God. Specifically, in his Word — by a positive, moral, and perpetual command binding all people in all ages — God has appointed one day in seven as a Sabbath, to be kept holy to him. From creation to the resurrection of Christ, that day was the last day of the week; since Christ's resurrection it is the first day of the week — called the Lord's Day in Scripture — and it will continue as the Christian Sabbath to the end of the age.	<i>One day in seven is God's Sabbath — now the Lord's Day.</i>
8. The Sabbath is kept holy when people, after preparing their hearts and arranging their ordinary affairs in advance, not only rest the whole day from their own works, words, and thoughts about their everyday work and recreation, but also devote the whole time to public and private worship and to duties of necessity and mercy.	<i>Devote the whole day to rest, worship, necessity, and mercy.</i>

Chapter 22 — Lawful Oaths and Vows

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. A lawful oath is part of religious worship: on an appropriate occasion, the person swearing solemnly calls on God to witness what he asserts or promises, and to judge him by the truth or falsehood of it.	<i>An oath solemnly calls God to witness the truth.</i>
2. People should swear only by the name of God, and with complete holy fear and reverence. To swear frivolously or rashly by that glorious and fearful name — or to swear by anything else at all — is sinful and to be abhorred. Yet in weighty and important matters, an oath is warranted by the Word of God, in the New Testament as well as the Old; so a lawful oath, imposed by lawful authority in such matters, ought to be taken.	<i>Swear only by God's name, and only in weighty matters.</i>
3. Anyone taking an oath should weigh the seriousness of so solemn an act, and affirm nothing he isn't fully convinced is true. He may bind himself by oath only to what is good and just, what he believes to be so, and what he is able and resolved to do.	<i>Swear only to what is true and what you can perform.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
4. An oath is to be taken in the plain, ordinary sense of the words, without wordplay or mental reservation. It can't obligate anyone to sin; but in anything not sinful, it must be kept, even when keeping it hurts — and even when it was made to heretics or unbelievers.	<i>Keep oaths in their plain sense — even when it hurts.</i>
5. A vow is similar in nature to a promissory oath and should be made with the same religious care and kept with the same faithfulness.	<i>Vows deserve the same care and faithfulness as oaths.</i>
6. A vow is to be made to God alone, not to any creature. To be acceptable, it must be made voluntarily, out of faith and a sense of duty — in gratitude for mercy received or to obtain what we lack. By it we bind ourselves more strictly to necessary duties, or to other things insofar as they help us perform those duties.	<i>Vows are made to God alone, and voluntarily.</i>
7. No one may vow to do anything God's Word forbids, anything that would hinder a commanded duty, or anything beyond his ability for which he has no promise of ability from God. On these grounds, Roman Catholic monastic vows of lifelong celibacy, professed poverty, and obedience to a religious order — far from being steps to higher perfection — are superstitious and sinful snares in which no Christian should entangle himself.	<i>Never vow what God forbids or what you cannot do — monastic vows included.</i>

Chapter 23 — Civil Government

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. God, the supreme Lord and King of the whole world, has established civil authorities to govern under him, over the people, for his glory and the public good. For that purpose he has armed them with the power of the sword, to defend and encourage those who do good and to punish those who do evil.	<i>God ordained civil government for his glory and the public good.</i>
2. It is lawful for Christians to hold public office when called to it. In office they should especially uphold godliness, justice, and peace, according to the sound laws of their nation — and for that purpose, they may lawfully wage war, now under the New Testament, when the cause is just and necessary.	<i>Christians may hold office — and may wage just and necessary war.</i>
3. Civil authorities may not take over the preaching of the Word, the administration of the sacraments, or the church's spiritual authority ("the keys of the kingdom"), nor interfere in any way in matters of faith. Yet, like caring fathers, they have a duty to protect the church of our common Lord — without preferring any Christian denomination over the others — so that all church officers can freely carry out their sacred functions without violence or	<i>The state must not run the church, but must protect everyone's religious liberty.</i>

danger. Since Jesus Christ has established a regular government and discipline in his church, no civil law should interfere with its proper exercise among the voluntary members of any Christian denomination. Civil authorities should also protect the person and reputation of all their people, so effectively that no one is allowed — in the name of religion or of unbelief — to insult, harm, abuse, or injure anyone else; and they should ensure that all religious assemblies can meet without interference or disturbance.

4. It is the people's duty to pray for those in authority, honor them, pay their taxes, obey their lawful commands, and submit to their authority for conscience' sake. An official's unbelief or different religion doesn't void his just and legal authority or free the people — clergy included — from their due obedience. Much less does the Pope have any power or jurisdiction over civil rulers in their domains or over any of their people — and he certainly cannot strip them of their realms or their lives on a judgment of "heresy" or any other pretext whatsoever.

Honor and obey rulers; the Pope has no authority over them.

Chapter 24 — Marriage and Divorce

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. Marriage is to be between one man and one woman. No man may have more than one wife, and no woman more than one husband, at the same time.	<i>Marriage is between one man and one woman.</i>
2. Marriage was ordained for the mutual help of husband and wife; for the growth of the human race through legitimate children, and of the church through godly children; and for the prevention of sexual immorality.	<i>Marriage is for companionship, children, and purity.</i>
3. All sorts of people who are capable of giving intelligent consent may lawfully marry. But it is the duty of Christians to marry only in the Lord: those who profess the true reformed faith should not marry unbelievers, Roman Catholics, or other idolaters; nor should the godly be unequally yoked by marrying people who live notoriously wicked lives or hold damnable heresies.	<i>Christians should marry only in the Lord.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
4. Marriage must not take place between people related too closely by blood or marriage, as forbidden in the Word. Such incestuous marriages can never be made lawful — so that the couple may live together as husband and wife — by any human law or by the couple's own consent.	<i>Incestuous marriages can never be made lawful.</i>
5. Adultery or fornication committed after engagement, if discovered before the wedding, gives the innocent party just grounds to break the engagement. Adultery after marriage makes it lawful for the innocent party to sue for divorce and, after the divorce, to remarry as if the offending spouse were dead.	<i>Unfaithfulness justifies breaking an engagement — or, after marriage, divorce.</i>
6. Human corruption being what it is, people tend to hunt for arguments to justify separating those whom God has joined together. But nothing except adultery, or desertion so willful that neither the church nor the civil authorities can remedy it, is sufficient cause for dissolving the bond of marriage. Even then, a public and orderly process must be followed; the persons involved are not to be left to their own wills and judgment in their own case.	<i>Only adultery or irremediable desertion dissolves a marriage — by orderly process.</i>

Chapter 25 — The Church

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. The catholic — that is, universal — church, which is invisible, consists of the entire number of God's elect: everyone who has been, is, or ever will be gathered into one under Christ, its head. This church is his bride, his body, and the fullness of him who fills all in all.	<i>The invisible church is all the elect of all time, under Christ.</i>
2. The visible church — also catholic or universal under the gospel (no longer confined to one nation, as it was under the law) — consists of everyone throughout the world who professes the true religion, together with their children. It is the kingdom of the Lord Jesus Christ, the house and family of God — outside of which there is no ordinary possibility of salvation.	<i>The visible church is all who profess the faith, with their children.</i>
3. To this universal visible church Christ has given the ministry, the Scriptures, and the ordinances of God, for gathering and perfecting the saints in this life, until the end of the age. And by his own presence and Spirit, according to his promise, he makes them effective for that purpose.	<i>Christ gave the church everything needed to gather and perfect his people.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
4. This universal church has been sometimes more visible, sometimes less. And particular churches — members of this universal church — are more or less pure depending on how purely the gospel is taught and embraced, the ordinances administered, and public worship performed in them.	<i>Churches are more or less pure — and more or less visible.</i>
5. Even the purest churches on earth contain both mixture and error, and some have degenerated so far that they've ceased to be churches of Christ at all and become "synagogues of Satan." Nevertheless, there will always be a church on earth to worship God according to his will.	<i>Even the purest churches err, but the church will never disappear.</i>
6. The church has no head but the Lord Jesus Christ. The Pope of Rome cannot be its head in any sense.	<i>Christ alone is the head of the church — not the Pope.</i>

Chapter 26 — The Communion of Saints (The Fellowship of Believers)

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. All believers, being united to Jesus Christ their head by his Spirit and by faith, have fellowship with him in his graces, sufferings, death, resurrection, and glory. And being united to one another in love, they share in one another's gifts and graces, and are obligated to carry out those public and private duties that promote each other's good, inwardly and outwardly.	<i>Believers share in Christ — and in one another's gifts.</i>
2. Professing believers are duty-bound to maintain holy fellowship with each other — in worship, in other spiritual services that build one another up, and in helping each other materially according to their abilities and needs. As God gives opportunity, this fellowship is to extend to everyone, everywhere, who calls on the name of the Lord Jesus.	<i>Fellowship means worshipping together and helping each other practically.</i>

3. The communion believers have with Christ does not make them in any way sharers in his divine nature, or equal with Christ in any respect — to claim either is irreverent and blasphemous. Nor does their fellowship with one another take away or infringe anyone's right to his own goods and possessions.

Union with Christ doesn't make us divine; sharing doesn't abolish property.

Chapter 27 — The Sacraments

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. Sacraments are holy signs and seals of the covenant of grace, directly instituted by God to represent Christ and his benefits, to confirm our belonging to him, to mark a visible distinction between the church and the rest of the world, and to solemnly bind Christians to God's service in Christ, according to his Word.	<i>Sacraments are signs and seals of the covenant of grace.</i>
2. In every sacrament there is a spiritual relationship — a "sacramental union" — between the visible sign and the reality it signifies. That's why the names and effects of the one are sometimes attributed to the other.	<i>The sign and the reality are spiritually joined.</i>
3. The grace displayed in or through the sacraments, when rightly used, isn't conferred by any power in the sacraments themselves. Nor does a sacrament's effectiveness depend on the godliness or intention of the person administering it. It depends on the work of the Spirit and on the word of institution — which both authorizes the sacrament's use and promises benefit to worthy receivers.	<i>Their power is the Spirit's — not the ritual's or the minister's.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
4. There are only two sacraments ordained by Christ in the gospel: baptism and the Lord's Supper. Neither may be administered by anyone but a lawfully ordained minister of the Word.	<i>There are only two: baptism and the Lord's Supper.</i>
5. As to the spiritual realities they signified and displayed, the sacraments of the Old Testament were essentially the same as those of the New.	<i>Old and New Testament sacraments signified the same realities.</i>

Chapter 28 — Baptism

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. Baptism is a New Testament sacrament, ordained by Jesus Christ. By it the baptized person is solemnly admitted into the visible church; and it is for him a sign and seal of the covenant of grace, of his being grafted into Christ, of regeneration, of the forgiveness of sins, and of his surrender to God through Jesus Christ to walk in newness of life. By Christ's own appointment, it is to continue in his church until the end of the age.	<i>Baptism admits a person into the visible church and seals God's grace.</i>
2. The outward element is water, with which the person is baptized in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit — by a lawfully called minister of the gospel.	<i>With water, in the triune name, by a minister.</i>
3. Immersing the person in water is not necessary. Baptism is rightly administered by pouring or sprinkling water on the person.	<i>Immersion isn't required; pouring or sprinkling is proper.</i>
4. Not only those who personally profess faith in and obedience to Christ are to be baptized, but also the infants of one or both believing parents.	<i>Believers and their children are to be baptized.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
5. Although despising or neglecting baptism is a great sin, grace and salvation are not so tied to it that no one can be regenerated or saved without it — nor is everyone who is baptized certainly regenerated.	<i>Baptism is important — but it neither guarantees nor is required for salvation.</i>
6. Baptism's effectiveness isn't tied to the moment it's administered. Nevertheless, through the right use of this ordinance, the promised grace is not merely offered but really displayed and conferred by the Holy Spirit to everyone — adult or infant — to whom that grace belongs, according to God's own will, in his appointed time.	<i>Its effect isn't tied to the moment it's performed.</i>
7. Baptism is to be administered only once to any person.	<i>Baptize each person only once.</i>

Chapter 29 — The Lord's Supper

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. On the night he was betrayed, our Lord Jesus instituted the sacrament of his body and blood, called the Lord's Supper, to be observed in his church until the end of the age: as a perpetual remembrance of the sacrifice of himself in his death; as a seal of all the benefits of that death to true believers; for their spiritual nourishment and growth in him; for their deeper commitment to all the duties they owe him; and as a bond and pledge of their fellowship with him and with each other, as members of his mystical body.	<i>The Supper: remembrance, nourishment, commitment, and communion.</i>
2. In this sacrament, Christ is not offered up to his Father, and no actual sacrifice is made for the forgiveness of anyone's sins, living or dead. It is only a commemoration of the one sacrifice Christ offered on the cross, once for all — and a spiritual offering of the highest possible praise to God for it. So the Roman Catholic "sacrifice of the mass" is a detestable insult to Christ's one and only sacrifice, the sole atonement for all the sins of his elect.	<i>It commemorates Christ's one sacrifice — it doesn't repeat it; the mass is rejected.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
3. In this ordinance the Lord Jesus has appointed his ministers to declare his words of institution to the people; to pray, and to consecrate the bread and wine, setting them apart from common to holy use; to take and break the bread, take the cup, give both to the communicants, and partake with the congregation. But they are not to give the elements to anyone not present in the congregation at the time.	<i>Ministers consecrate and distribute the elements to the gathered congregation.</i>
4. Private masses — receiving the sacrament alone, from a priest or anyone else — are contrary to the nature of the sacrament and to Christ's institution. So too are denying the cup to the congregation, worshiping the elements, lifting them up or carrying them around for adoration, and reserving them for any supposedly religious use.	<i>No private masses, no withholding the cup, no adoring the elements.</i>
5. The visible elements, properly set apart for the uses Christ ordained, have such a relationship to Christ crucified that they are sometimes called — truly, but only sacramentally — by the names of what they represent: the body and blood of Christ. Yet in substance and nature they remain truly and only bread and wine, just as before.	<i>The bread and wine represent Christ's body and blood — but remain bread and wine.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
6. The doctrine that the substance of the bread and wine is changed into the substance of Christ's body and blood by a priest's consecration or any other means (commonly called transubstantiation) is contrary not only to Scripture but to common sense and reason. It overthrows the nature of the sacrament and has been, and still is, the cause of many superstitions and gross idolatries.	<i>Transubstantiation is contrary to Scripture, sense, and reason.</i>
7. Worthy receivers, outwardly partaking of the visible elements, also inwardly by faith — really and truly, yet not physically but spiritually — receive and feed on Christ crucified and all the benefits of his death. Christ's body and blood are not physically in, with, or under the bread and wine; yet they are present to the faith of believers in this ordinance just as really — in a spiritual sense — as the bread and wine are present to their physical senses.	<i>Believers truly feed on Christ — spiritually, by faith.</i>

8. Ignorant and wicked people who receive the outward elements do not receive the reality they signify; instead, by coming unworthily, they become guilty of the body and blood of the Lord, to their own condemnation. So all ignorant and ungodly people — being unfit to enjoy fellowship with the Lord — are unworthy of the Lord's table, and as long as they remain so, they cannot be admitted to it, or partake of these holy mysteries, without great sin against Christ.

The unworthy eat judgment on themselves and must not be admitted.

Chapter 30 — Church Discipline

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. The Lord Jesus, as King and Head of his church, has appointed a government in it, administered by church officers, distinct from the civil government.	<i>Christ appointed a church government, distinct from the state.</i>
2. To these officers he has entrusted "the keys of the kingdom of heaven": the authority to retain and remit sins — to shut the kingdom against the unrepentant, by the Word and by church censures, and to open it to repentant sinners, by the ministry of the gospel and by lifting censures, as the occasion requires.	<i>Church officers hold 'the keys' — admitting and excluding from fellowship.</i>
3. Church discipline is necessary: to reclaim and win back believers who have fallen into sin; to deter others from similar sins; to purge out the "leaven" that could infect the whole batch; to vindicate the honor of Christ and the holy profession of the gospel; and to avert the wrath of God that could justly fall on the church if it let his covenant and its seals be profaned by notorious and stubborn offenders.	<i>Discipline restores sinners, protects the church, and honors Christ.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH**IN BRIEF**

4. To accomplish these purposes, the officers of the church proceed by steps: admonition (formal warning); suspension from the Lord's Supper for a time; and excommunication from the church — according to the nature of the offense and the person's degree of guilt.

Its steps: warning, suspension from the Supper, excommunication.

Chapter 31 — Church Assemblies (Synods and Councils)

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. For the better governing and building up of the church, there ought to be assemblies commonly called synods or councils. The overseers and other leaders of particular churches — by virtue of their office and the authority Christ gave them for building up, not tearing down — have the authority to appoint such assemblies and to meet in them as often as they judge it useful for the church's good.	<i>Churches should meet in assemblies — synods and councils.</i>
2. Synods and councils have ministerial authority (serving under Scripture, not above it) to settle controversies of faith and cases of conscience, to set down rules for the better ordering of public worship and church government, and to receive and act with authority on complaints of mismanagement in the church. When their decrees and decisions agree with God's Word, they are to be received with reverence and submission — not only because they agree with the Word, but also because of the authority by which they were made, as an ordinance God appointed in his Word.	<i>Their decisions bind when they agree with God's Word.</i>

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
3. Since the apostles' time, all synods and councils — general or local — may err, and many have. So they are never to be made the rule of faith or practice, but used as a help to both.	<i>All councils can err; Scripture alone is the rule.</i>
4. Synods and councils are to deal only with church matters. They are not to meddle in civil affairs of the state — except by humble petition in extraordinary cases, or by giving advice for the satisfaction of conscience when the civil authority asks for it.	<i>Councils handle church matters, not civil affairs.</i>

Chapter 32 — Death and Resurrection

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. After death, our bodies decay and return to dust, but our souls — which neither die nor sleep, having an immortal existence — return immediately to God who gave them. The souls of the righteous are made perfect in holiness and received into the highest heavens, where they see God's face in light and glory while awaiting the full redemption of their bodies. The souls of the wicked are cast into hell, where they remain in torment and utter darkness, kept for the judgment of the great day. Scripture recognizes no other place for departed souls besides these two.	<i>At death, souls go immediately to heaven or to hell.</i>
2. On the last day, those still alive will not die but will be changed. All the dead will be raised with the very same bodies they had — no others — though with different qualities, and these will be reunited with their souls forever.	<i>All the dead will be raised — the same bodies, gloriously changed or not.</i>
3. By the power of Christ, the bodies of the unjust will be raised to dishonor. The bodies of the just will be raised to honor by his Spirit and made like Christ's own glorious body.	<i>The unjust rise to dishonor; the just to glory, like Christ's own body.</i>

Chapter 33 — The Last Judgment

PLAIN ENGLISH	IN BRIEF
1. God has appointed a day on which he will judge the world in righteousness by Jesus Christ, to whom the Father has given all power and judgment. On that day, not only the fallen angels will be judged, but every person who has ever lived will appear before Christ's judgment seat, to give account of their thoughts, words, and deeds, and to receive judgment according to what they've done in the body, whether good or evil.	<i>Everyone who has ever lived will be judged by Christ.</i>
2. God's purpose in appointing this day is to display the glory of his mercy in the eternal salvation of the elect, and the glory of his justice in the damnation of the wicked and disobedient. On that day the righteous will enter everlasting life and receive the fullness of joy and refreshment that comes from the Lord's presence; but the wicked, who don't know God and don't obey the gospel of Jesus Christ, will be cast into eternal torment and punished with everlasting destruction, away from the presence of the Lord and the glory of his power.	<i>The righteous enter everlasting life; the wicked, everlasting punishment.</i>

3. Christ wants us absolutely convinced that there will be a day of judgment — both to deter everyone from sin and to give the godly greater comfort in their suffering. And he wants the timing of that day unknown, so that people will shake off all false security, stay always watchful (since they don't know the hour the Lord will come), and always be ready to say: "Come, Lord Jesus. Come quickly. Amen."

The day is certain but unknown — so stay watchful and ready.